

“DELHI GOVERNMENT IS SITTING

With Kashmir on the boil and internal security in a shambles, Union Home Minister Shivraj Patil is the man in the hot seat. Weak laws and weaker intelligence networks are compounded by a lack of will to combat terror. And as terrorists strike at will in places far and wide, everyone is blaming Patil for the mess that his ministry itself is in. He spoke with Editor PRABHU CHAWLA for a special interview for Headlines Today. Excerpts:

Q. When do you expect a solution to the Amarnath problem?

A. You are asking for a time-frame. When matters are related to the emotions of the people, we should try to solve them as quickly as possible. I think we will be able to solve this matter in a very short time.

Q. They are hoisting the Pakistani flag in Kashmir. Both sides are emotional and attacking each other. You have been trying to bring them together. Where is the hitch?

A. It's in the emotions. It is in the philosophy that some people adopt.

Q. Isn't it a fact that the Government at the local and the Central level failed to anticipate events?

A. I am not sitting and making a judgement. It is for the people to judge.

Q. But as home minister you must be concerned. It has to be resolved somehow. There has to be some give and take.

A. That is exactly what we are trying to do. And we would like to accept a formula which is acceptable to both, people living in Jammu and the people in Kashmir.

Q. Parties should be condemning the Pakistani flag being hoisted in Srinagar.

A. By condemning, you get the pleasure of abusing somebody, but you don't solve the problem.

Q. L.K. Advani has sent you a letter suggesting some way out.

A. Advani is the leader of the Opposition and he has been in the government. We won't take his letter lightly; we will examine it and discuss this matter with him.

Q. There is a feeling that somebody is encouraging them from across the border.

A. Again it is nothing but blame game.

HEMANT CHAWLA



Q. Do you think Pakistan is responsible for the trouble?

A. You are all the time asking me to blame this man or that man.

Q. I am not asking you, the whole country believes that.

A. You believe, whatever you think is proper. Don't ask me, a member of the Government, to say things that I don't want to say.

Q. You are a soft-spoken and a non-controversial person. But there is a perception that you are the villain of the whole show.

A. I do not know who says so.

Q. Everybody says so. The editorials say so.

A. Not everybody. If you are saying this thing, I can't help it.

Q. What plans do you have to control terrorism?

A. We are a country of 112 crore. The police-population ratio is adverse and we have to correct it. Our police are trained to control mob, traffic, to investigate, but not

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